post-coup invasion of Haiti under US auspices. Russia has remained a blocking power in the UN Security Council, increasingly alienated from NATO. China is the clearest counter-force to the West, consistently exercising full strategic autonomy, despite its evident dependence on external markets and monopolies.

Their modes of engagement with Africa are no less diverse or contradictory. To be sure, all are beneficiaries, including China, of the neoliberal prying open of African economies, conducted since the 1980s under the aegis of the West and its multilateral agencies. Yet they all maintain a higher sensitivity to matters of national sovereignty, even though there remains an unresolved race question everywhere, with paternalist tendencies towards Africa. Moreover, there is potential for the breaking of monopolies in certain sectors – and, by extension, the Western stranglehold – especially by China and its trade finance and oil-for-infrastructure strategies.

Given the tendencies and counter-tendencies of this current conjuncture, it is necessary to rekindle the strategy of non-alignment on new terms. In so doing, it is imperative to avoid the highly ideological 'equivalence' between Western imperialism and the emerging semi-peripheries, whose clearest expression is China-bashing.

Whatever one makes of the new semi-peripheries, they are certainly not the main agents of imperialism, nor are they militarising their foreign policies. Nor, for that matter, are they cohesive nations internally, given the ongoing super-exploitation on which their extroversion is based.

The first principle in a new non-alignment should undoubtedly be non-participation in the military project of the remaining superpower, that is, the United States, as well as its junior partners in NATO and its AFRICOM initiative. The second is the devising of a strategy with respect to both the established and the aspiring scramblers to enable a larger degree of manoeuvre for national development.

Few countries in Africa have used the existing room for manoeuvre in the current conjuncture in the interest of social and economic progress; and when they have, they have typically been labelled 'corrupt' or 'tyrannical' by the West. Zimbabwe, the country that has gone the furthest in breaking up monopolies and devising a pragmatic non-alignment policy (actually named 'Look East'), has been one of the most despised for doing so.

The new non-alignment implies not only resisting the West militarily and 'looking East/South', but also setting conditions on all external relations. Such resistance can only be effective by collective strategies on the continental and sub-regional levels.